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Ken Plummer

Life story interview with Paul Thompson

2015

Principle investigator's thematic highlights

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Ken Plummer

Interviewed by Paul Thompson

01 August 2015

1. Family and Class

So, my earliest days. I was born on April 4th, 1946, in Palmers Green, in North London, which is "kippers and curtains land" as they say, because it's right on the border of Wood Green and going into Southgate, and so it was, it was, it was aspirational working-class, right on the edge of being, trying to be middle-class - and it failed abysmally! My parents - Ethel, was my mum, and she came from the North of England, she came from Houghton-le-Spring, County Durham, a mining village. She had 12 brothers and sisters, and all the men, bar one, went down the mines, so she has a mining background. My father was born in Tottenham.

They were very good, loving, kind parents, and I have nothing but love for them both. You know, there's no problem about either of them in that sense, they really loved both me and my brother, looked after us both, it was a loving background. But it wasn't a communicative one….

Do you feel they had aspirations for you, like education and occupation and so on, or not?

Absolutely. Not my mother, my father. My father wanted me and my brother to go to university, and no one in our family had gone to university before. And my brother passed his 11+ and went to Glendale Grammar School, and he was very good at biology and he went to Hull University. And then three years later – my brother's three years older than me –I went through the whole process again, and I didn't go to university, I went to Enfield College, locally. (p 1-3)

Now, there is a very important thing to be said here about class, because people - it's very messy to say "I'm working-class", but I am working-class, after a fashion. My father was a barber, but not a self-employed barber. My mother worked in jobs, all my life, she's worked, she worked in factories, nights in factories, she'd worked in laundries. She eventually got shop work. She became the Saturday woman at Woolworths. She did home work, painting

models and so forth, all the time. And we never had any money, basically.

It was only a big fluke when I was about 13, that they bought a house. The house was next door – we lived in rooms when I was young .- one living room, two bedrooms, and a kitchen, and a bathroom that we could use on Thursday nights. That was an upstairs flat in Belsize Avenue, 57 Belsize Avenue. But Mum looked after the neighbours quite well, and they were two old, old ladies, and when they died, somehow or the other, there was an arrangement made that they would buy the house off them, and it was about £2,000 – a lot of money for those days, but, nevertheless, they could [get a deposit for] it. They really worked hard and saved.

That was a real changing point of life, because once you enter the property classes several things happened. Therefore, they were aspirational working-class, very aspirational working-class – not my mother so much, but my father, in particular. He had a smart accent, and I'll never know where that came from, because I'd got that accent from him, somewhere or the other. Anyhow, then I had my own room, and I never had my own room in the other house, I shared it with my brother. And we had our own bathroom, we could go in the bathroom when we wanted! So this was about the age of 13. (p 18-19)

2. Schools and teachers

But then I passed the 11+ and that was good news. On one level it wasn't good news, but I'll tell you that in a second. But anyhow, we went to this grammar school, and then I became a stuck up little grammar school boy! I mean, I lost all my friends who went to the secondary modern school.

But when I was in the sixth form at Wood Green School, two striking things there – one, I became the school magazine editor, and that became - I was devoted to that, very very engaged with that sort of extra-curricular activity. And at the end of the first year, the Headmaster called me into the office and told me that he wanted me to be Head Boy. I said to him, “I can't be Head Boy because I stammer”. He said, “Well, we won't make you do any talking”. So I became Head Boy….

I suppose I was in their eye, because of the school magazine. Because it was a new school, it had been an amalgamation of two grammar schools – Glendale Grammar School, and Trinity Grammar School – put together to form this rather controversial Wood Green School, in a brand new spanking building, with a brand new headmaster, and this was the

brand new school magazine. It was very modern and jazzy, and I'd hurled myself into it, really had. I was editor for two years, and it took over my life, I mean, almost to the detriment of any academic work. And I find it very interesting because I've had this kind of interest in doing that sort of thing which, I can see now. You know, I did that [newsletter] *Sociological Life* in the Department, for a number of years, and, and even the book I did last year is a remnant of wanting to do a nice school magazine, in a way! In a funny sort of way! So there is a continuity there. And I think I came to their notice because of that.

I don't think it was because I was particularly bright, academically, because I never was especially…. I absolutely wasn't into sport. And that year, at the end of the second, I must have been a favourite, I must have been obnoxious! I have thought about this, I must have been an obnoxious little boy, who was a creep!

In the lower school, there were many nice teachers, and I could go through them all, but nothing particularly distinguished, and I was not a distinguished student…. Anyhow, in the sixth form, I think all my teachers were highly influential, but in very different sorts of ways. I can go through each one if you wanted me to. The one that was most influential, and I've forgotten his name, was Len - it's interesting I know his first name [more easily than] his second name - anyhow, he was my form master and he taught me economics. I think, although I was never particularly good at economics, it did give me a very different way of thinking about the world. I did 'O' Level Economics in one year in the sixth form, and then 'A' Level in the second year. Len Hadley was his name, and he lived in Palmers Green too, and I would see him in the library. He was a very wise man, you know, quite an older man to me then, he_was probably in his forties. I remember going to hear him give a lecture once. He was very concerned, and he encouraged me to apply for social sciences and so forth. A very nice man indeed.

But the other extreme was in my English literature, where I got a grade A, and I had this teacher called Mr. Carey. I had several teachers, actually, and each of them – we had three different English teachers – they were all very nice in their own ways, but taught very different things. But Mr. Carey was clearly a man who'd just come from Oxford, and he introduced me to Gerard Manley Hopkins, I remember him doing that. But he didn't not like me. We had an antagonistic relationship, and the reason for that was that, in those days, I was a little Christian boy, and he didn't like little Christian boys who would speak up with religious viewpoints when reading Gerard Manley Hopkins. He liked the poetry, but not the message! Okay! So I had to do well in English literature to prove him that I wasn't quite the funny boy that he thought I was, so I got a grade A in it, and I really worked hard in it. And

for the first time in my life, I read way beyond what was given to me. I was buying books on English literature, on Shakespeare, and reading secondary commentaries and so forth, and that's the first time I ever did anything like that. And I enjoyed it, I enjoyed doing that sort of thing. So he kind of taught me that, in a funny way, education is an act of resistance, you go to lots more books and read them so you know what he's talking about, and you can argue with him! (p 5-7)

3. Coming Out and Coming Out Stories

I really liked the Youth Club because of the dancing and the music, and actually, ostensibly the girls. Because it was very odd, I had a lot of girlfriends in those, in my early days…If you like, I could take you right back to when I was five, or four even, you know, I could say that I was always attracted to boys, and in my class, they were the ones I was attracted to. But equally, most of my friends, even in the junior school, were girls – and that's an odd thing. So I was attracted to the boys, and I was having girl friends, I was friendly with the girls, and my three best friends were all girls – Janet, Jean and Margaret – and I'd hang around with them all the way through junior school. Then they went to the secondary modern school and I stayed with them for a year or two, and then we just drifted apart.

But they weren't aware - they didn't think of you as different, these girls? .

Well, I was never a sporty boy. That's immediately a big difference. I don't know how I'd function in the world today now, if I was a little boy, because it seems to me that all little boys have to play football and be obsessed with balls and sport. If you're not, I think you'd be spotted straightaway.

So you were conscious of this difference, but you weren't really talking to other people about it?

KP: Oh - only subconsciously aware of it. Yeah. I mean, it never - when I - I can't quite work out precisely. Certainly it was all very clear to me by the time I went to Enfield College, so at the time I was 18. And in the sixth form, I certainly had crushes on some of my friends

in the sixth form, and very strong - but I had girlfriends. And I remember going through the whole motion of - I mean, I thought it was right, but I never did anything. It was all rather ritualistic, when I think about it, and it was not very fair on the poor girls, some of whom I can see were edging me on to do all sorts of quite advanced sexual things with them, but I never did. Even deep kissing I didn't really want to do! So, you know, something was up! That's a whole other story which, no doubt, we can go on to at some point. You know, talking about coming out. (p 10-11)

There's a genealogy now of the notion of coming out, and I experienced it personally, and I read it in books in the sixties and I watched it kind of unfold in different ways. There's a big chunk of it in my book on *Sexual Stigma*, and I was applying it to these other groups about when they come out - when can a paedophile come out, for example? Or, indeed, a sadomasochist. So you can apply it all the way through. And then by the late eighties and nineties, there were archives of it, and there were coming out stories all round the world. So you had coming out in India, coming out in Africa, everybody was doing coming out stories. Then there came the deconstruction of coming out. So nobody's coming out any more because everybody's come out already, or it's not straightforward. So there's a whole big story to be told about coming out!

I'm part of that story, like anybody who's gay is, and has a different set of responses. My own coming out was, first of all, to myself, then I told my parents, and I told my parents, well, in this critical year, 1966, and they sent me to see a therapist and all the rest of it. And then coming out to my friends, and the first friend I told it to, I said, “You know, well, I've got something to tell you. I'm gay”. He said, “So am I”. And so it went on. So, I mean, 1966 was my critical coming out year, and then, of course, I wrote about it in 1975. But there was another coming out, which was in the Gay Movement in 1970, which is when I first marched in the streets, and then that became the real meaning of coming out, publicly, in the streets, for everybody to know. So there are lots of different meanings of it. (p 51-2)

So my coming out experience, my first gay bar experience, was about 1966, and that was right in the heart of Soho, in a top bar; and then the following night I was taken right down into a basement… That was really my kind of immersive fieldwork moment! (p 21)

4. Towards Symbolic Interactionism: Stan Cohen and Paul Rock

What had happened was that a large number of bright young things from the LSE had invaded Enfield, so there was a whole new explosion of sociology going on there with bright new people. So one of those bright young people, for example, was Stan Cohen, and another one was Jock Young. There was a whole string of them, actually, who all went on to be very successful in different walks of life – academic ones, but some of them went on to be administrators. …

In the second year, I did Structure of Modern Britain, Comparative Sociology, Social Psychology, which I loved. Stan Cohen taught me that, and he taught formally, - the discipline was Social Psychology, but tucked away in there was his favourite, which was Symbolic Interactionism, and it came off on me. So I knew that's the theory I liked, from that moment onwards. And then in the third year, he taught me Criminology. Well, that was, that was a turning point really. And he encouraged me, and encouraged me a great deal, and Jock Young did too, because he was also there, but he wasn't full-time at the time. And [Stan] let me write an essay on homosexuality. And that made me read a lot of books. By this time, which is the third year, so I'm about 20, I'd started to read these books, and Stan gave me an incredibly high mark. I can't remember what it was now, but it was just, you know, a bowled over mark and comments were just over the top nice, and supportive and encouraging…

So it was at that moment I decided that I would, perhaps I could go on to do a Ph.D.. I mean, life is a bit funny like that. I suppose at no point did I ever think that far ahead that I could ever do any of these things. It was like, as you succeeded at one stage, like you pass the 11+, so then you realise when you can study, and then you get to the sixth form, and you realise when you can pass exams, and then you go to uni - you didn't realise you could go to university, so then you realise, at each stage - I mean, if you'd ever told me I'd be a professor one day, I'd have laughed, you know! It just, it's very slow and incremental…

Stan is one of the most important people in my life. First of all, he was doing the "Mods and Rockers" study at that time, and I remember him going into a lecture and saying he'd like some students to join him for the weekend, to go to Clacton to do some interviewing. And I really - a lot of the sadness is that I never volunteered to do that. I should have done… But there was something about him… I saw an intellectual at work - you know, somebody who was way beyond your classroom teaching, but who, a man who was thinking

and reading and enjoying it a lot, and who could also be very nice. Stan had a very warm - I mean, he wasn't the most outgoingly friendly person, but he was very warm and caring. And he was looking after me, in a way, I felt looking out for me. Because he did encourage me to go on to do a Ph.D….

[At LSE] I moved from David Downes, very quickly, to Paul Rock, who is another lovely man, and actually, a wonderful supervisor, and a tremendously important influence on my life…He was a very nice person [with] a very gentle way about him. But he was also, it was in his bones to be a symbolic interactionist ethnographer. I mean, he couldn't think any other way, it was in him, and it just oozed out of him to - everything I learnt from him was just how to think like that, and it couldn't have been otherwise. He was very good at commenting on my thesis in great detail, and it was always this oozing interactionism which was all about, the ambiguity of life, the lack of certainty about things, the multiple meanings of everything, the flow of life, the complexity of it. So even if I'd wanted to be a Marxist, which I did, I couldn't be, because it wasn't as simple as that. You know, it was like that all the time. And he supervised me from, from 1968 to 1973. (p13-16)

5. Michael Schofield

I went to see Michael Schofield, who'd written the only book at that time which was on sociological aspects of homosexuality, which was published in 1966. We studied him in *The Sexual Behaviour of Young People* [1965], in 1966 too, so I wrote to him and I said, "I think I want to go on studying this", and he was - I mean, there's a whole other story to be told about Michael, his significance in my life…Well, I wrote to him. He replied very kindly.

I went to see him. He lives in Belsize Park, Hampstead. .. Michael comes from Leeds - Schofield's of Leeds, a big department store. He's very rich. He's very upper classy/middle classy, and very posh, but without any pretension at all, actually, and doesn't dress up. He's a Labour supporter, Civil Rights person. But never mind, I was actually meeting people that I was not used to meeting. I wasn't used to going to Hampstead even at the age of 21, and I wasn't used to knocking on people's doors who were really really posh. It was another world. But Michael was very warm, very friendly, very welcoming. Remember, I was only 21, I wasn't revoltingly ugly, so he did make a mild pass at me. …

Well, Michael has his own interesting story. You remember, I interviewed him. But

also I've written various obituaries - so I know a lot about Michael, there's a whole other story to be told there. But the quick story is that he decided – he did his Social Psychology degree at Cambridge – he decided, during that process, that he was gay, although he didn't know that. It wasn't very painful for him, he said, but he wanted to know more about it. So he started studying it, and he used the library there to research it, and, but he couldn't publish it under his own name because it would have been too scandalous for the family, so he wrote it under the name of Gordon Westwood, and he published the first book, which was *The Homosexual in Society*, which he published roundabout 1951. Then he turned that into a major study, he got funding for it, which was published in 1961 [as *A Minority Report on the Life of the Male Homosexual in Britain*.] He was very involved, in that period, with the Wolfenden Report, because he was doing research also on the sociological aspects of homosexuality, which talked about homosexuals in prisons, homosexuals in psychiatry, and homosexuals who weren't any of those things – and the differences between them.

So that is his trajectory up to about 1965, and then he wanted to branch out, and the Health Education Council got him to do a wider study of sexuality, which was *The Sexual Behaviour of Young People*, which was followed up in the early seventies with *The Sexual Behaviour of Young Adult*s. For that I was actually involved as a Research Officer – not the interviews - well, I did do interviews, but the Research Administrator. So I met him about 1967ish ...

It was the same time - there's a whole world now, there's many things to be told about that too, because I also met Anthony Grey, who was the Director of the Homosexual Law Reform Society at that time, and Michael was involved with the Homosexual Law Reform Society. I became involved with the Homosexual Law Reform Society, and the Albany Trust, and that became my fulcrum, if you like, for the period roughly from '67ish through to Gay Liberation Front, which was 1970/71ish. (p 19-20)

6. Ph D Research

[Originally] the whole idea of the Ph.D. was to examine the consequences of the changing law, because it was due to be changed in 1967, and I could see that happening, and so that was the whole point to the Ph.D.. It didn't quite work out like that in the end … And so I did get to do it at the LSE…. I started off with the goal of it being a policy type thing, and then I did my fieldwork and so forth, and it finished up being a theoretical thing in the interactionist

mode, heavily influenced by Paul, and I said, "Can you do this? Can I do a thesis that isn't like the full-scale research findings?" He said, "I can't see why you can't". So that's why it became as it did. It was based upon quite a lot of fieldwork, but it wasn't written up like that.

I did a lot of interviews with all kinds of - I advertised in various magazines – gay magazines – and got 40/50 people to interview in all sorts of different backgrounds. Some of them were quite frightening, I remember. I did fieldwork, but fieldwork was really my coming out experience, because I would study in gay bars, so I was hanging around a lot of gay bars and taking fieldwork notes – I didn't know quite whether it was fieldwork notes, or me coming out!

I did a study of all the London gay bars at that time, of which there were about a hundred. People say there weren't gay bars in those days, but there was at least a hundred. And I did a box card system for each gay bar in London, so there were two or three major clusters – one was bang slap in Soho, where it, funnily enough, is still. The second was out on the limbs of Earls Court, where there were several sprinkled round, and the third was around Chelsea. Those were the three major areas. A huge number of clubs and pubs and all kinds of different sorts of things, but they were all very secretive, so, for many of them, it did involve going down a winding staircase into deep cellars, and you'd have to ring bells and say passwords, and all sorts of things like that - or you could be up winding stairways up to top rooms in places you know!

But they were all a bit like that. It's only in the early seventies you start getting slightly more public places, and then you get big discos and things. So there was a lot of these. And there were pubs too, and you wouldn't know the pub was gay until you got in it, and then they might often hustle in pubs, or they'd have maybe themed pubs, so some would be hustling, some would be sadomasochist, some would be young. My own one was this young coffee bar, called "Le Duce Coffee Bar", in D'Arblay Street, I think it was in Soho, and I'd go there for all night sessions. No alcohol. Dancing to Tamla Motown? Yes! Records. And meeting other - because there was no drink there, because it was actually meant to be for - there were a lot of predators around, but it was mainly [trendy] young men who were dancing away the night, and then hopefully finding someone to go home with, which I did once or twice, but not very often

And at the same time I was working with the Albany Trust. They did a quantitative study of social [of the homosexual], which was a big survey, so I was working on that. I also, they were also doing a study of couples, and I did a lot of interviews around gay marriage and gay couples – and this is 1968/70 – and I wrote a short - well, one of my first ever published

papers was actually called, "Men in Love: Observations on the Gay Couple", which was based upon about ten gay couples interviewed. (p 20-3)

7. John Gagnon and Bill Simon

But to go back to John Gagnon, the quick story here is that I [first met him with Michael Schofield in 1970; and he then became my External Examiner in 1973.] We stayed in touch. And then there's the Essex episode, because … John came over here in 1983/4 [as an exchange between Essex and Stony Brook]. I really got to know John [best then] in 1983/84, that's when we became the greatest of friends. He stayed with us in Wivenhoe most nights, when he came up for the week [to Essex], he'd stay with us, so I got to know him very well.

Then, of course, I got to know Bill Simon through Santa Barbara. It happened to be one summer when I was doing Summer School, he was there, and I got to know him and his wife very very well. And John and Bill could not be more different, but they're both lovely people. They're both incredibly serious intellectuals. … Bill Simon and John Gagnon are incredibly important to my life, yes.

When you say they were both very intellectual but very different – what did you mean then?

I'll summarise it in one anecdote. If, as we did, several times, at various ASA Conferences, want to go for a meal, John would look for the swishest restaurant in town, and be quite high faluting about it, though he was working-class in origin. Bill would say, "I'm not interested in food. If we're going out to eat, I'll have a burger". They were both working-class lads made good, and they made good at the Kinsey Institute, and they're both two of the most intelligent people I've ever met in my life. They're both very forbidding in a way. They would talk in [different] ways - but John was slightly imposing and spoke with gravitas, whereas Bill, who was equally clever, if not more so, spoke as if he didn't know anything. And he was "mmmmmerrrr", and then he'd come out with the most complicated sentence (p 27-9)

(Obituaries by Ken Plummer in *Sexualities* of Bill Simon, Vol 4, 2 (2001): 131-4; and John Gagnon , Vol 19 (2016): 608-14.

8. Kinsey and the Kinsey Institute

I went to the Kinsey Institute in 1976. When I came to Essex in '75, I got a grant, but this one aspect of it included an American trip to find out what sex research they were doing there. It took me to the Masters and Johnson Institute, it took me to the Kinsey Institute, and it took me to various places going on in California where there was work going on, and in New York. So I went eight weeks, touring around. It was my introduction to America, and American life. Gay life I saw for the first time in America, and all these things. But it did include two weeks in Bloomington, Indiana, at the Kinsey Institute. And I was actually in awe of them too. They were very inspirational. Well, at close up, it was a bit tarnished just ever so slightly. I went there for a week conference, and the people there were the big names, … but we did funny things. We did masturbation workshops, which - for the uninitiated, you sit in a circle with women behind you, or men in the front, and we'd talk about how we wanked! [They would listen to us] first of all, and then they'd talk about their wank.

I learnt, of course, quite a lot from it. You know, men are furiously an object focus, and women are, you know, lying back with much more kind of oozy imagery! We had a male fashion show… We had, we went skinny dipping, naked, in a nearby [river] - so I was being introduced…. [to a] quite sexualised and much less formally academic [environment], even in Kinsey's days, than was respectable enough.

Kinsey, himself, did most of the work on the Kinsey research. He did a huge number of interviews…. He liked interviewing, and he did a huge number of them. And he was obsessed with it all. He was driven to get these things. So, I mean, there's a lot wrong with the Kinsey findings, of course – the methodology and all the rest of it – but it's a tremendously important cultural event that it happened. I think something else would have happened if it hadn't happened, but it really did start changing people's awareness, and the language they had to talk about sexuality and so forth, all that was transformed through him. But the Institute, itself, was beginning to fade somewhat, because Kinsey had been dead for ten years, and they weren't quite sure where they were going. (p 30-1)

(For Ken's obituary of Bill Simon, *Sexualities*, 4, 2 (2001): 131-4)

9. Masters and Johnson Institute

They were in, they were in St. Louis, Washington. Completely separate [from Kinsey]. And a completely different thing. And that was a very different conference again, because that was - well, it was the opposite. It was all physiological. We went to the laboratories and looked at how people were wired up, and they spoke with a degree of formality – it was a proper conference. There was none of this larking around stuff, and it was very serious, and they spoke in very technical language, and sex research was a very serious matter. In a sense, you could see the two different strands: do you want to make it academic and formal, or do you want see that sex is a lot of fun really? You know, we don't wanna make it go all dry and take the fun out of it. And you saw that there, the contrast between those two places, which was unique to me, really, going from one conference to the next conference. (p 31)

10. The Sexual Variations Project and the difficulties of life story interviewing

I put in for a research grant. And I got it, believe it or not! Actually, it's my only major research grant, and it was only for a piffling amount of money now, but it was important. And that research was, is a significant follow-on from the previous one, because it was to open up what I knew about homosexuality – can it be applied to a whole array of other groups? So it was looking at paedophilia, sadomasochism, transvestism, transgenderism, asexuality, and sex workers/prostitution, and sexual dysfunction, and others. Really quite a ragbag, but the common thread was that many of these things had been thought about as clinical problems before, pathologies of one form or the other, studied by psychologists, or by biologists, or by criminologists, or by medical people, and that wasn't adequate in the same way as homosexuality had been. Once you put it into some sociological framework, it all takes on a very different set of understandings. And that's what I was trying to do - with Annabel Faraday, of course. And it was a very successful research in the sense that it shaped the rest of my life, but it's never been published. Little bits have leaked out, but all those interviews, which are in a box upstairs, have never seen the light of day. And there's a whole story about that, which is that I didn't like them, I didn't trust them. The interviews. They were wholly inadequate. In every way you could think of.

It led to the book, *Documents of Life*, which, in a way, is an account of the problems of doing this kind of work. Because I became more aware of it - I mean, *Documents of Life* grew out of the research, because I was using that method. The second [edition of the] book, which is wholly different from the first one, is actually all about the complexities and almost the impossibilities of doing it. I remember, in the Department, doing graduate seminars on the impossibility of doing life story research… "Yes, you can go a long way with it, but it's all that's not said, that you're not getting at, and in principle you can't get at it". And the fuzziness of it, and the messiness of it, the inchoate ambiguity of it all, which, as I knew, becomes absolutely clear when you start doing the interviews. You're very good right now, you're letting me ramble, which is what I tried to do too - because if you let people ramble, they come up with all sorts of things that lead them all sorts of places. But if you start structuring in any way at all, really, apart from the slightest little prompt now and then, then they just start filling up what you want to hear… So, anyway, that led to *Documents of Life*, where I was obsessed, for a while, with the methodology of it all. …

You had all those different categories of sexuality, and you did interviews in all those different groups?

I think so. Yes. It all took different shapes. Annabel, for example, focused upon transgender and did an intensive long life-story of one [transvestite] person. We also joined organisations and got their magazines and all the rest of it. But the major thing there was Claude, a transvestite person, who lived not that far away from here… I interviewed mainly the paedophiles and the sadomasochists and a few oddballs here and there. …

I suppose my major finding, at that time… was that everybody I interviewed was uniquely flagging up a wholly different area of sexual research. So I interviewed a shoe fetishist, I interviewed someone who was preoccupied by being whipped. I interviewed a man who made straitjackets and was into the idea of encasement and complete lack of losing control over your body. I interviewed a very scary man who was into medicine and internal sadomasochism – feeding things into the body and using tension from within. I interviewed a middle-class man and his wife and his daughter in their chintzy living room about the organisation they ran for sadomasochists, heterosexual sadomasochists, and the limits of power and pleasure together. I was sitting there with their china teacups, drinking this. And I went to a party where people were pouring oil on each other, and setting fire to it. And I just thought, "I can't make any sense of this!" But each one led to a bigger world. (p 34-6)

11. Paedophilia and the Media

I wish I had published on sadomasochism and not on paedophilia. Unfortunately I did publish on paedophilia, I published about five articles on paedophilia, I got carried away with it – and they are there to haunt me! … Well, the main thing that I did was, again, a life-history of one person… But the other part of it was I, because of the circumstances of the time – it was 1976 to '79 – and the paedophile organisations were set up, two of them – PAL, "Paedophile Actions for Liberation; and PIE, the "Paedophile Information Exchange" - and I had friends on the fringe of them, through the Gay Movement, who said, "Well, you know, sure, if you want to study us, then you're fine". So I joined, I had access to some of their letters and their magazines, and I could interview a number of them, and I did…. I got a lot of material, and it's really quite interesting. And then I wrote my papers around it. But it's quite clear, because I was listening to the paedophile's voice, that that is read as me being completely pro-paedophilia, …

I was giving my first paper on it, and it was a session on paedophilia, where there were three or four other speakers, at a conference called "Love and Attraction", in Swansea. Well, the incident there is I got pursued by the *Time Magazine*, and I didn't want to speak to them. And_it has, generally speaking, been my policy, I don't want to talk to media, I don't trust media at all, so I've always been very low-key on it. I mean, some people take the exact opposite stance, but I run away from it. And this was my first experience. it did lead to a lot of trouble, that Conference…

Anyhow, I mean what's been picked up, all these articles - I've taken them off my website, but people can still find them because other people have put them up. And when I'm quoted word for word, it sounds like I'm a defender and sponsor of paedophilia which, indeed, I was perilously close to being at the time of being with these people. … There's a very interesting long historical story to be told about the whole thing, and one fine day, if I'm up to it, I might want to tell it. It's such a complicated area, but now there's only one narrative about it, you know, it's all child abuse, it's all violent and nasty, and it's all terribly destructive. And I think a lot of it is, most of it is. But there is some other version of it around, and that's what I was telling, and that's not acceptable. And, and I'm left with living with a world that, actually, has turned, over the past 30 years, to make this the major, major scapegoat, the major folk devil.… It's like sadomasochism I described to you, it isn't just one

paedophilia –there's multiple paedophilias of all different kinds, and a lot of it would never harm a child, it won't even engage with a child, it's just the love of a child. (p 33, 36-8)

12. Reflexivity in Research

I suppose there's a bigger point, first of all, to make, which is that everybody these days talks about self-reflexivity in research and all the rest of it, but I mean, I've been engaged with self-reflexivity and research ever since I ever started research, and if you like, all my research is bound up with the personal reflexivity. There's nothing I've ever done that isn't kind of engaging with me personally. Now, I don't know that's true of all research, but I have a suspicion that large amounts of research are actually involving people much more than ever's let on. But with me, it's been just unmistakeable because it's been so in my face about it. I study homosexuality because I'm homosexual… So that's the story of my life, it's perpetual reflexivity in research…

I got this very nice research project going, I set it all up to look at sexual variety. I suppose you could say I was a sexual liberationist at the time. Annabel [Faraday the project's researcher] was too, she was with this boyfriend, I thought she was heterosexual… It's only a two and a half year project, and the beginning was all wonderful, and bit by bit, of course, Annabel became a lesbian, Janet Parkin left her husband and got into women, and Linda Molotch started having a relationship with a woman in the third year of the sociology students – a mature student… It was as if everybody who touched the research was becoming gay! You know, the Right Wing's worst theory was coming true! How was it happening?

But then the next stage was, of course, Annabel became a radical Feminist, and that was the next major feature of my life, really – dealing with radical Feminism, because it meant that a lot of the liberationist ideas I had, I had to give up. Because sexual liberation is not the same as gender liberation, and there was a tension between them of the first order. Annabel experienced it personally, because there she was, doing a project about sexual liberation, and dealing with people where she felt, "Well, it wasn't right, these people shouldn't doing these things - some of them, they're deeply oppressive to women". And so, they were the consequences of, of sexism in one form or the other, or patriarchy…. But she was very worked up, I was very worked up, we were trying to do this also in our personal

lives, experimenting with these things, and it was chaos! It was one of the most significant and important periods of my life. (p 40)

13. Jeffrey Weeks and Mary McIntosh

Well, he's another great inspiration of my life, without doubt. I met Jeffrey when I was doing my Ph.D. at the LSE, and I can't remember whether I met him before or after GLF, but I think before. He was plodding away, really, with some project he wasn't particularly excited by, but he was a Research Assistant at the LSE on some archival work… And then we were both at the very first GLF meeting, at the Gay Liberation Front meeting at the LSE, in October, 1970. There was only about 12 of us there, and that just exploded into a major social phenomenon, political phenomenon, for the next six months of my life, I suppose. I met my first boyfriend there – Peter Urbach – and Jeffrey met his first lover there – Angus [Suttie] – who subsequently died with HIV and AIDS. So we became great friends.

And also Mary McIntosh, of course, was another very critical person who was there. … Isn't it true that all research is just a pattern of networks and friendships really, in the end? … I didn't see her, physically, until 1970, '69, when I gave my first paper at an LSE Seminar - "Underlying Conceptions of Homosexuality" it was called. She came up to me afterwards, and she wasn't at all what I expected, because she was - I mean, it's very hard to say this really, but she was a very beautiful, well-dressed woman! … I mean, she was many different things, I think, in her life, in different ways… She came to Essex in '75 too….There was no planning from the Department's point of view, "Oh, let's have a Lesbian and Gay Centre"… She didn't do lesbian and gay studies when she came to Essex, she didn't do it at all, ever. Nobody really realises that. She did Feminism, full stop. And Socialism, full stop…. [We talked], huge amount. You know, she became a very good friend

About Jeffrey Weeks, it's just that I was thinking the first book which made an impression, was Coming Out*, wasn't it?* …

It came out of his experiences in the Movement. It's in two parts, and the first part is really the early homophile movement in England, and all the different people that were engaging with it, like Edward Carpenter and people like that. And then the second part is an account of

the emergence of the modern Gay Movement. And then he does draw upon a little bit upon my *Sexual Stigma* stuff, to start beginning to talk about identities, politics and change, and so it's - well, we had lots of talks, and we had the Movement in front of us. We were on marches together. We we talked intellectually quite a lot and I haven't talked, in my life, with a huge number of people, intellectually, funnily enough. So he's been very important.

The people I've mentioned so far, Michael, Paul, John and Bill, Jeffrey, Mary, and Stan, of course, hugely important, intellectually….I expect all the people you interview have different clusters of people, depending upon which discipline they've got. But this is a very different, distinctive, quite distinctive little cluster of people which are not the mainstream of sociology, full stop. (p 43-6)

14. The Making of the Modern Homosexual (1981) and Modern Homosexualities (1992)

The first one is laying the groundwork of the constructionist historical approach of homosexuality, and it brought in a number of people who were in the Department at the time. Virtually everybody - well, everybody in the book had some connection with the Department. The second one was an open invitation to a number of people, but within the Department too, and it was how far we'd come, actually, in that ten year period, and it set up a whole series of new agendas about globalisation, and post-modernism, and citizenship and so forth. It was not as significant a book as *The Making of the Modern Homosexual*, in terms of impact, because there was already a lot more stuff around by then. There wasn't very much around in 1981, but by 1991/2, there was a lot more. And I'd always thought there might have been a [third] book in my head, which would bring together a number of people about global homosexualities, but I never did it. Except I have done recently, because I've done my own book on it really…. That's *Cosmopolitan Sexualities*, it's the new book that's just come out. (p 46-7)

15. AIDS Research and Campaigning

I had decided that my next project was going to be - because I was into doing fieldwork and

life stories, I thought, I'm going to do ethnographies of what they used to call a "VD Clinic", or "Sexual Health Clinic" now. And I'd made contact with a hospital in London. [But] we never got the money. And I also decided that AIDS was more important, so I shifted. I'd already done a lot of work in that area of sexual health, and I was getting into the Sociology of Medicine – for one year, I taught a course… So I'd started doing some work on HIV and AIDS, and I did cultural work on it really. I was in Stony Brook at the time, for a while, and I did research on AIDS in New York, and I went to the New York Centres, and the cathedral. People were dying like flies. It was a horrendous scene. The long and the short of it is that I did publish quite a few things, but they were popular things, [such as] articles in *Gay Times* on AIDS in San Francisco, AIDS in New York, and AIDS in London - "A Tale of Three Cities" … And then I wrote play reviews, because, actually, there were a lot - the new Culture of AIDS were producing fantastic drama and film, so I got very interested in that. So it was really edging me into cultural studies in an early form…. Then, of course, Tony Coxon came along to Essex, and brought big AIDS research with him. But I had already decided to back out of it all, because - it was very simple, I was crying too much. It really was depressing. Of all the research I've done, it was just unbearable.

I sometimes think, today, I want to do more research in unbearable areas, and I remind myself that I'm no good at unbearable areas. I break down, it's just so awful. And it was. AIDS was. And what is equally awful now, is just how shockingly we've forgotten it all… It was a graveyard both in San Francisco and in New York. Horrendous. But also an amazingly galvanising time for the Gay Movement, to suddenly organise itself properly. To start, if you like, growing up to being open to sensible debates and arguments, and not just screaming and shouting... The old gay activists of the seventies threw away their beards and their beads, and their kaftans and their jeans, and started wearing suits and ties, and white shirts, to meet the officials to debate AIDS. I think it's a powerful image, because that is what I saw going on, you know. People who were, before, all radical, could no longer afford to be that radical, they'd have to be liberal assimilationists to get the money they needed to deal with the terrible epidemic. (p 47-8)

16. Queer theory

Queer theory appears in the academic scene somewhere in the late eighties, probably about '87/'88, and it comes out through Literature Departments, and to some extent [was] very

American. It is about messing up all the kind of categories we've got, messing up all the binaries we've got, engaging with transgression, and re-reading texts for their hidden messages …

I am not a queer theorist though! Which leads to the question of why I'm not. Actually, it's not fair to say I'm not a queer theorist, but I'm not a champion. I think it's very important, actually, and in the research in this field now, it's one of the areas. If you read what the sociologists do, it's very dry and very dull, and very boring, and very limited, and very repetitive, and if you look at what queer theorists do, they're constantly breaking up new grounds and challenging what you think, in very obscure ways and often very difficult to read, but they're constantly moving, moving the barrier, so to speak, whereas sociologists don't. So I do enjoy reading queer theory, and a bit of me is a queer theorist, but I'm actually still an old-fashioned symbolic interactionist! (p 53-4)

17. Finding a Politics

I suppose I've never been a strong activist, out there on the barricades all the time, except for the Gay Liberation Front moment when I was, and I regard that as probably the most important moment of my life. I did it for about two, two to three years, and then I, it receded from me, so that's when I got back to normal. But it did leave a huge political awareness in me that I hadn't got before. My family wasn't political, I wasn't political, and going to the church and then during the courses I did, I never was - I mean, I was always on the Left, so to speak, and I think it's always been that way, but it's never been an organisational one. I've never craved to be in Parliament, I've never craved to be an activist of any type…

I needed to find a politics that would suit me, that went with it. There's a lot of work flirts around on that issue, there's nearly always a politics in everything I write, actually, it becomes very explicit from - well, it's there in *The Making of the Modern Homosexual* of course, but it comes very explicit in *Telling Sexual Stories*, which is subtitled, "Power, Change and Social World". A huge chunk of that book's devoted to the issue of power – who has the power to hear narratives, who has the power to tell stories, and who's silenced, and all the rest of it. It becomes a major theme of everything I do really. But it wasn't as clear to me at the beginning, even though it was there, as it became later on. And with that, I kind of opened up to more theories that talked about that, it just means I'm open to many more theoretical persuasions than just interactionism, and that allows me to do it. So I take the

interactionism and build on it, and build on it, really, what is most obvious about it, which is the humanism I do use the word "humanism" right from the beginning, but now, it's absolutely dominant in what I think about, and the question becomes the politics of all humanity to make the world better for all humanity, and it goes right away from sexuality.

So there's quite a lot of my stuff, now, which doesn't mention sexuality… I'm unashamed now about the fact that social science should be clear about its values and where it's going, it should make them explicit, and they're part of a politics, and there's no point in doing it if you're not thinking it's going anywhere for a better world. (p 54-55)

18. Relativism and Interpreting Interviews

Telling Sexual Stories is written like it's a post-modern book. But the danger with post-modernism is its relativism, and I'm not a relativist. I'm not a relativist in terms of epistemology, that is to say I don't hold that all knowledge is equal. It's not. I mean, some things are higher truths than others. But I'm not … a realist, that I think the world is absolutely surely there. It's much more fragile, it always is much more fragile because it's always changing. It's 'emergent', as the word goes… I have a sense that we struggle to get to it, but we'll never get to it. It's unknowable really, but we have to struggle to get there…,

Well, in terms of doing research and doing life stories, would you say the same kind of thing, that we can never know the validity of this particular interview, but we have to struggle to get there?

I would say that exactly, yes… [For example, I mentioned a life story I recorded for the Sexual Variations project.] It is significant, it's a good life-story, but it does reveal the contradictions of what people say and do, because I got to know him very well, and what he said in the interviews was totally at odds with what he did in his life – but that's another story. Another disillusionment with life-story method. And I thought the more you got to know a person, the more you saw them in their real life, the more you'd see how it all fits together with their story. But he'd go on telling me these stories that didn't match up what he would say to other people when I was in groups with them, and, indeed, what I saw in his conduct. So that was the life-story. …

I was being a bit critical, sounding a bit critical of this whole method, I am, because I'm critical of everything in that sense, but I actually, oddly enough, think it's the best method we've got. That's the irony, really. Because if you think about large-scale research, or a lot of interview, straightforward interview research, it short-circuits knowledge like mad. You know, it presumes that they know what they're looking for, it presumes the person can answer articulately, or simply say "Yes" or "No", it presumes so much about knowledge and the social world. The life story and the narrative doesn't do that. It makes everything a problem. Every sentence can be unpacked further and further, the whole life is bound up in simple statements, and it's ambiguous, and changing. It constantly changes from context to context, and on and on and on. And it's so much more complicated. So this interview is not going to get at any absolute truth about me because there are thousands of things being missed out, but it's much nearer than if you came in and gave me ten questions and checked them off in a box, which wouldn't give you anything….

I think you said you got disillusioned because there were people that you'd interviewed who said one thing when you were interviewing, and then another thing at a group meeting and so on. So how do you deal with that discrepancy, then?

Well, you know it. That's the point, you know. So you don't take what people say as simple truths, and you match it up with other bits that they say, and you point out, in your discussion what the ambiguities and the changes are, and you constantly stress the complexity of it rather than that is necessarily what they were…. If you gave me a particular theme to think of, say on when I was in GLF and in the Homosexual Law Reform Society, and you said to me, "Can you tell me about what you were dreaming about at that stage of your life?" Then I might be able to dig up some dreams, but it would give you a very different story of what I was up to. Or if you ask me, "Who did you have sex with during the course of those things?" it would give you a very different story….

But you see what I mean? Just the slightest different emphasis and the whole story would have come out totally different. … That's when it became clear to me, doing that research. I think I'd already had a whiff of it beforehand, but then it became really clear that the stories change in the context. I mean, [a key] point of *Telling Sexual Stories* is to say the narratives we give off, are historically bound, and contextually bound. So you couldn't tell those stories of sexuality in the 1940s, they weren't accessible for people to say, the conditions weren't right to tell them. (p 55-8)

19. Writing an Illness Narrative

But in between those two books – *Intimate Citizenship* and *Cosmopolitan Sexualities* - I was ill. That was three years of my life, basically, when I was not functioning properly, and some of the time not functioning at all. I thought that was the end, really. I mean, you ... you have an illness like that, you don't hold out much sense of a future after it because you've just got to get through on a day-to-day basis. So there's lots that could be said about the illness, but I'll leave that aside for the moment, because when I came out of it, I then had to find what to do. I hadn't got a job any more. I know when I was ill I did say to myself, "Well, tonight is a good time to die, really", because at 60, I'd done everything that I wanted to do. I didn't have anything - I mean, I didn't have the next project to do so it was fine, I could go! But as it turned out, I was better than that, I could work out what to do! And the first thing was to write my illness story, which was just so important to do, I'm so glad I did that…. Have you ever seen it? I don't know. The full-length narrative of my illness?...

Well, it goes through really theme by theme. What I did, for three months - so I'm ill from, well, from really 2004 through - my surgery is in March, 2007. It takes four months to recover from that, in one form or the other – Everard says it took longer –but anyhow, I'm back functioning by the summer of 2007, and I start writing on the 1st September, more or less, for three months. I get up, and in my writing spot – which is first thing in the morning –I just wrote what came into my head from the memories of the illness. So it was free-flowing. I did keep notes, but they're not always readable because I had this wobbly feint hand, and they're not very well-organised, and sometimes they're unintelligible. But I did keep notes. One of the first things I did, in Santa Barbara, when I was diagnosed, I went out to get myself a nice shiny black notebook, which I filled up slowly, which only a storyteller sociologist would do! It's one of the first things they do when they're ill! (p 63-64)

20. The Power of Narrative

But anyhow it strengthened the view I had of narratives. Because the power of narratives is extraordinary in lives. Because first of all the power of my gay story was very important in my life, and there's no question of it, that finding a way of articulating your

sexuality crystallises your sexuality if it's problematic, as it was, when I was very young. And in the illness, well, I say this, I've said it in a few lectures from time to time, which is that - vitally for my illness was medicine. It saved my life. But it only saved half of it. Story-telling saved the other half. Which is to say that, "Yes, they saved my liver, but without, if you like, a way of handling those three years of organising it and making sense of it, not dwelling on it forever of my life", I had to get it under control, and I did that through the story-telling. And then when I'd finished writing the story, I actually think my illness came to an end. It didn't come to an end with the transplant, it came to the end when I'd finished the story. But I didn't finish it, everything's still going on, but finished, like, the writing stage of the story. (p 66-67)

21. A World View

The worst thing is the world! I just can't bear the state of the world, and I can't afford to think about it too often. I do, I regularly think about it, because the sociology drives me into it, but I have to get away from it because it's so awful. And I'm really dumbfounded, regularly, by how the world has been going on for thousands of years, has made such a mess of it. It's just unbelievable that we've just got it so wrong after such a long period of time. I can't understand that each generation doesn't learn from the next generation, because it's actually relatively simple. I do say this in the new book, that's why it's on my tip - on the tip of my head - tip of my tongue. I'm not saying anything new when I say that there are very simple things in life – empathy, and people ... understanding other people, trying to care for people, and trying to be kind, and trying not to be too nasty, although we can all be a little bit, from time to time, and seeking a fairer, juster, more equal world. That's not too difficult for us to have grasped, is it? That's why I'm an Absolutist now, not a Relativist, because they're things to me, they're fundamental and somehow, we don't grasp them. (p 88)